

THE OWNER-BUILDER PATHWAY

A Melbourne-Based DIY Guidance Platform for Owner-Builders

Business Plan

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"The Owner-Builder Pathway" is a working title; see Appendix A for brand name options.

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1. Executive Summary

After 30 years in architectural design and project management, Kate Dunn is launching a digital guidance platform that helps Melbourne owner-builders manage the full journey from site selection through to completed construction, without needing to pay full-service project management fees. The platform combines a self-paced course, a tiered digital resource library, a private community, and optional paid one-on-one expert support, giving clients the ability to do as much of the process themselves as they choose, with a clear path to professional help when they get stuck.

The business is designed around two complementary revenue mechanisms. The core product (tiered digital guides, templates and course content) is sold largely as one-time purchases, because most owner-builders only need this material for the 12–24 months of a single project. Recurring, low-effort income then comes from three places: an optional ongoing community/membership add-on for clients still mid-build, a steady stream of new customers entering the funnel every month (driven by search traffic and referrals once the content library is built), and higher-margin paid add-ons such as 1:1 consultations, plan reviews and permit pre-checks that draw directly on Kate's expertise.

This structure matches the stated goal (a product that keeps generating income with limited ongoing effort) more realistically than a pure subscription model, because it doesn't rely on convincing someone to keep paying monthly for a house they've already finished building. Once the content library, course and community shell exist, the main ongoing work is content marketing, light community moderation, and delivering the paid consulting sessions that clients opt into.

Illustrative modelling in Section 10 suggests the platform could realistically move from a content-building phase in the first three to four months, to roughly \$80,000–\$95,000 in revenue across Year 1 as the funnel gets underway, growing toward \$200,000+ in Year 2 and \$350,000+ in Year 3 as organic traffic, referral partnerships and repeat/referred customers compound. These figures are planning assumptions, not guarantees; they should be pressure-tested against real conversion data once the platform launches.

2. Business Concept & Value Proposition

2.1 The Problem

Building costs in Australia have risen roughly 74% since the end of 2019, and a typical new detached home now costs \$1,800–\$2,500 per square metre to build. Full-service project management and builder margins add substantially on top of that. At the same time, the Melbourne/Victorian regulatory process (siting requirements, planning permits, and the Building and Plumbing Commission's (BPC, formerly the Victorian Building Authority) owner-builder Certificate of Consent process) is where most prospective owner-builders get stuck. It is technically possible to self-manage a build in Victoria, but the information is scattered across council websites, the BPC, private building

surveyors and forums, and a single costly mistake at the siting or permit stage can delay a project by months.

2.2 The Solution

A structured, Melbourne/Victoria-specific platform that walks owner-builders through the entire pathway: site and title checks, zoning and overlays, planning permits, design brief and documentation, the BPC Certificate of Consent and owner-builder learning module, engaging a building surveyor, staged construction, inspections, and final occupancy, broken into a self-paced course, downloadable templates, and a community of peers, with Kate's 30 years of design and PM experience available on a paid, as-needed basis rather than bundled into every client's fee.

2.3 Value Proposition by Audience

- **For the DIY-motivated owner-builder:** a clear, sequenced pathway that replaces guesswork with checklists, templates and worked examples specific to Victorian regulation, at a fraction of full project management cost.
- **For the nervous first-timer:** the reassurance of a community of peers further along the same journey, plus the ability to book a paid session with a qualified expert at the exact moments of highest risk (siting, permit lodgement, contract review).
- **For Kate:** a productised way to package three decades of expertise that can serve far more clients than one-to-one project management ever could, while keeping the highest-value, highest-margin work (paid consulting) reserved for people who specifically opt in and pay for it.

3. Market Opportunity

Precise annual counts of owner-builder permits in Victoria are not published in an easily citable single figure (the Building and Plumbing Commission and Data Vic publish raw building permit datasets that would need to be filtered to isolate owner-builder Certificates of Consent). However, the directional case for demand is strong:

- **Construction cost inflation:** national dwelling construction costs are up roughly 74% since 2019, materially increasing the incentive to save on builder margins and project management fees by self-managing part or all of a build.
- **Persistent trade and material cost pressure:** industry commentary through 2026 continues to point to rising material costs and squeezed builder margins, which tends to push more cost-sensitive projects toward owner-builder and knockdown-rebuild/renovation paths rather than full turnkey builds.
- **Regulatory complexity creates a real pain point:** Victoria requires a Certificate of Consent from the BPC for any owner-builder project valued over \$20,000 (inclusive of labour and materials), a mandatory online learning module, engagement of a building surveyor, and a

restriction to one owner-builder permit every five years, all before construction can begin. This is precisely the kind of process where people are willing to pay for clarity.

- **Adjacent products validate willingness to pay:** interstate owner-builder course providers (mostly NSW/QLD-focused, e.g. SAFE RITE, Owner Builder Centre, ABE Education) charge \$119–\$600 for statutory owner-builder education and companion project-management resources, showing an established market for paid, structured owner-builder guidance, though with no strong Victoria-specific, design-and-PM-led competitor (see Section 4).

Sources: BPC/VBA eligibility and process pages (vba.vic.gov.au, bpc.vic.gov.au); Landmark Valuations construction cost report 2026; RLB Q4 2025 market commentary via MacroBusiness; SAFE RITE and Owner Builder Centre pricing pages.

3.1 Target Customer Segments

- **Renovator/extender:** owner-occupiers adding a second storey, extension or major renovation to an existing Melbourne property, typically the largest and most time-poor segment.
- **Knockdown-rebuild / new dwelling:** owners demolishing and rebuilding on their existing block, needing the fullest version of the pathway from siting through occupancy.
- **Secondary dwelling / granny flat builders:** a fast-growing segment given planning reforms favouring small second dwellings, often lower budget and highly cost-sensitive, a strong fit for the lower-priced tier.
- **Regional Victoria self-builders:** rural and peri-urban blocks where the owner-builder route is more established culturally, and where access to affordable professional advice is more limited.

4. Competitive Landscape

The clearest gap in the market is a Victoria-specific product led by a qualified architectural/PM professional, combining education, templates, community and paid expert access in one place. Existing players are either statutory-training-only, interstate-focused, or generic content without a credentialed practitioner behind them.

Competitor	Focus	Price point	Gap vs. this platform
SAFE RITE	NSW owner-builder statutory course + free members' project-management resources	~\$189 one-off	NSW-only statutory content; not Victoria-specific; no paid 1:1 access to a senior practitioner
Owner Builder Centre	NSW/QLD/WA owner-builder courses and permits	\$300–\$600	No Victorian offering; course-only, limited ongoing community
ABE Education / Edway / Train Online	State-based statutory owner-builder certification (various states)	\$119–\$600	Compliance-training focused; minimal design/siting/zoning guidance or community
Local architects / building designers	Full design service, sometimes advisory-only	\$150–\$250+/hr	High cost, not productised, no self-serve option, limited

Competitor	Focus	Price point	Gap vs. this platform
	consults		scalability
Generic YouTube / forums	Free, fragmented content	Free	Not Victoria-specific, not sequenced, no accountability, no credentialed source

This platform's differentiation is threefold: Victoria/Melbourne-specific regulatory sequencing (siting, planning overlays, BPC process), a named, credentialed expert (30 years of design and PM experience) rather than an anonymous course provider, and a genuine tiered offer that lets clients choose pure self-serve or paid expert backup, rather than an all-or-nothing choice between DIY forums and a full-fee project manager.

5. Product & Service Structure

The offer is structured as three purchasable tiers (largely one-time, project-length access) plus an optional ongoing membership and a menu of paid, bookable add-ons. This hybrid avoids asking a client to pay indefinitely for a project they've already completed, while still creating the recurring, low-effort income stream Kate is after, driven by a constant intake of new customers rather than the same customer paying forever.

Tier	What's included	Price (indicative)
Foundations (self-guided)	Full digital guide (siting, zoning, planning permits, BPC Certificate of Consent process, design brief, trade tendering, staged construction, inspections, occupancy); permit and siting checklists; contract/scope-of-works templates; self-paced core video course; 12 months' community access (read & post)	\$247 one-off
Builder (guided + community)	Everything in Foundations, plus: extended phase-by-phase video course with case studies; project milestone/schedule template aligned to Victorian approval timelines; monthly live group Q&A; moderator-supported community access	\$497 one-off (optional \$29/mo membership after 12 months for clients still building)
Concierge (guided + expert support)	Everything in Builder, plus: two 60-minute 1:1 sessions with Kate (siting/design review; pre-construction review); one round of permit documentation review; discounted rate on further consulting	\$1,490–\$1,990 one-off

5.1 Paid Add-Ons (a la carte, bookable)

- **1:1 consulting:** ~\$220/hr, broadly in line with Melbourne independent design/PM advisory rates
- **Siting & zoning pre-check:** flat fee ~\$350
- **Permit documentation review:** flat fee ~\$250
- **Design/plan review session:** flat fee ~\$300

These add-ons are the highest-margin part of the business and the main lever for Kate's direct time, so they should be positioned as premium, scarce, and bookable only through a calendar tool (e.g. Calendly) with clear caps on weekly availability to protect the “little ongoing effort” goal.

5.2 Community

The community is the retention engine: it is where Builder- and Concierge-tier clients ask questions, share progress photos, and get peer support, reducing the number of questions that would otherwise land on Kate directly. Moderation can be handled by a part-time contractor or advanced graduate/former client once volume justifies it (see Section 9).

6. Pricing Strategy

Pricing is anchored against three references: interstate statutory owner-builder courses (\$119–\$600), typical Melbourne design/PM consulting rates (\$150–\$250+/hr), and the scale of money at stake in a build (a \$500,000+ project makes a \$247–\$1,990 guide an easy relative decision if it credibly reduces costly mistakes). Recommended approach:

- **Founder pricing:** offer the first 50–100 customers a discounted rate (e.g. 30% off) in exchange for testimonials and case studies during the soft-launch phase.
- **Payment plans:** offer 2–3 instalments on the Builder and Concierge tiers to reduce purchase friction on higher price points.
- **Annual price reviews:** revisit pricing yearly against regulatory changes, competitor moves and demonstrated cost savings delivered to past clients.
- **Avoid discounting the add-on consulting rate:** this protects the value of Kate's direct time as the business scales the self-serve tiers.

7. Technology & Platform Recommendation

The platform needs to combine course delivery, a membership/paywall, a community space, downloadable resources and a booking tool for paid consults. Rather than one perfect platform, most owner-builder-style businesses at this scale use two connected tools:

Platform	Best for	Indicative cost	Note
Kajabi	All-in-one: courses, membership paywall, email marketing, checkout, basic community	~\$179–\$249/month	Best single-platform option if Kate wants one login and one system; strongest course/marketing tooling
Circle +	Best-in-class community (Circle)	~\$89–\$120/month	Stronger

Platform	Best for	Indicative cost	Note
Teachable/Podia	paired with a lighter course/checkout tool	combined	community experience; slightly more setup complexity running two tools
Skool	Simple, low-cost combined community + course space	\$99/month + 2.9% of revenue (or \$9/month + 10%)	Cheapest to start; gamified community can drive engagement; less sophisticated marketing/funnel tooling

Recommendation: launch on Skool or Kajabi to minimise upfront cost and technical complexity, and reassess after 6–12 months once member volume and revenue justify Kajabi's higher fee or a move to Circle for a richer community experience. Pair with Calendly (bookings), Stripe (payments, if not native to the chosen platform), and an email tool (native to Kajabi, or ConvertKit/MailerLite if using Skool).

8. Marketing & Customer Acquisition

Because the goal is income with limited ongoing effort, marketing should prioritise channels that compound (organic search, referral partnerships, evergreen content) over channels that require constant spend and attention (paid ads), though paid ads are a useful accelerant once the funnel is proven.

8.1 Content & SEO (primary, compounding channel)

- **Cornerstone blog content:** targeting high-intent searches such as “owner builder permit Victoria,” “siting requirements Melbourne,” “BPC certificate of consent,” “owner builder insurance Victoria”; each article linking to the relevant guide/course tier.
- **YouTube case studies:** short walkthroughs of real (consenting) client projects, showing before/after and the specific regulatory hurdles cleared; doubles as course preview content.
- **Free lead magnet:** a short “Melbourne Owner-Builder Permit Checklist” PDF in exchange for an email address, feeding an automated nurture sequence toward the Foundations tier.

8.2 Partnerships & Referrals

- **Referral relationships:** with land surveyors, town planners, private building surveyors and material suppliers who see prospective owner-builders before Kate does; formal referral fee or reciprocal promotion arrangements.
- **Past client network:** Kate's 30 years of PM/design clients and industry contacts are a ready-made warm audience for the soft launch and testimonials.

8.3 Community & Social Proof

- **Existing Facebook/online owner-builder communities:** genuine participation (not spam) to build credibility ahead of launch.
- **Testimonials and cost-saved case studies:** the single most persuasive asset in this category; prioritise capturing these from the first cohort.

8.4 Paid Acquisition (Phase 2+)

Once organic conversion data exists (expect 3–6 months post-launch), test Meta and Google Search ads against the lead magnet and the Foundations tier directly, using early customer data to build lookalike/interest targeting.

9. Operations Plan

9.1 Kate's Ongoing Time Commitment

The design intent is to front-load effort into content creation (Months 1–4) and then minimise ongoing hands-on time to: producing 1–2 pieces of content per month, hosting the monthly live Q&A, delivering booked 1:1 consults (capped weekly), and periodic content updates when regulations change.

9.2 Team & Outsourcing (as revenue justifies)

- **Community moderator / customer support (contractor, part-time):** from roughly Year 2, once membership and community volume exceeds what Kate can casually monitor.
- **Content/video editor (freelance):** to keep production quality high without consuming Kate's time on editing.
- **Bookkeeper/accountant:** from launch, for GST, BAS and income tax across a now-recurring revenue business.

9.3 Legal, Compliance & Risk Controls

Because Kate is a qualified design/PM professional selling advisory content and paid consultations, scope and liability need to be deliberately managed; this is a genuine risk area addressed further in Section 11.

- **Clear terms of service and disclaimers:** stating the guide/course is general educational information, not site-specific professional advice, and does not replace a registered building surveyor, private certifier or the statutory BPC process.
- **Professional indemnity insurance:** confirm with Kate's insurer and professional body (e.g. Architects Registration Board of Victoria, if applicable) whether paid 1:1 advice under this new business model is covered, and whether any registration obligations are triggered by paid design/siting advice given outside a traditional engagement.

- **Content review cadence:** a standing quarterly check against BPC/VBA and local council rule changes, given the regulatory landscape is actively evolving in 2026.

10. Financial Projections (Illustrative)

These figures are planning assumptions to stress-test the concept, not forecasts or guarantees. They should be revisited with an accountant and updated with real conversion data after launch.

10.1 Key Assumptions

- **Launch:** content build in Months 1–3 (no revenue); soft launch Month 4; public launch Month 5.
- **Tier mix:** roughly 60% Foundations, 30% Builder, 10% Concierge, giving a blended one-off purchase value of ~\$465.
- **Customer growth:** new customers/month ramping from ~5 (Month 4) to ~40 (Month 12) in Year 1, then compounding via SEO and referrals in Years 2–3.
- **Add-on attach rate:** ~15% of Builder/Concierge customers book a paid consulting add-on averaging ~\$250.
- **Optional membership:** modest uptake (~30% of Builder-tier customers) of the \$29/month post-project membership, averaging ~6 months' retention.

	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
New customers (approx.)	180	400	650
One-off product revenue	\$83,700	\$186,000	\$302,300
Add-on consulting revenue	\$2,700	\$15,000	\$30,000
Optional membership revenue	–	\$10,000	\$35,000
Total revenue (approx.)	\$86,400	\$211,000	\$367,300
Platform, payment & tooling fees	\$4,500	\$7,000	\$9,500
Content production (video/design)	\$20,000	\$8,000	\$8,000
Marketing (organic tools + paid tests)	\$8,000	\$25,000	\$40,000
Contractor support (moderation, editing, bookkeeping)	\$3,000	\$18,000	\$32,000
Insurance, legal & professional fees	\$5,000	\$4,000	\$4,000
Approx. net income before Kate's own time	\$45,900	\$149,000	\$273,800

Illustrative model only; excludes GST, income tax, and the opportunity cost of Kate's own time delivering consults. Validate against real launch data before relying on these figures for financing or planning decisions.

10.2 Path to “Little Ongoing Effort”

The model shows the mix shifting over time: one-off product sales remain the largest single line, but recurring membership and add-on consulting grow as a share of revenue, and content marketing (built once, then compounding) replaces the need for constant active selling. The main scalability risk is that add-on consulting is capped by Kate's available hours, which is by design, since the goal is to keep her direct time bounded while the self-serve tiers carry most of the growth.

11. Risk Analysis & Mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Regulatory change (BPC/VBA rules, thresholds, council overlays) makes content outdated or inaccurate	Quarterly content review cadence; clear “last updated” dates on every guide; consider a small update-alert email to past customers when material changes occur
Professional liability / scope creep from paid advice	Written disclaimers and terms of service; confirm insurance and registration obligations before offering paid 1:1 advice; keep paid consults advisory rather than sign-off/certification work
Slow initial traction while SEO/content compounds	Lean on warm network and referral partners for the first 6 months rather than relying solely on organic search; keep Year 1 financial expectations conservative
National competitors (SAFE RITE, Owner Builder Centre) expand into Victoria	Move to capture the Victoria-specific, credentialed-practitioner positioning early; build community and testimonials as a moat that's harder to replicate than course content alone
Kate's time becomes the bottleneck as demand for consults grows	Cap weekly consulting slots; raise the consulting rate before adding hours; invest add-on revenue in productising more of the guidance into self-serve content
Membership churn once a client's project finishes	Expected and acceptable: the business model is designed around one-off sales and new-customer flow, not indefinite subscriptions; use churned members as a source of testimonials and referrals
Platform/technology dependency	Choose a platform with data export capability; keep the email list as the owned asset independent of any single platform

12. Launch Roadmap

Phase	Timing	Key activities
0. Validate & set up	Weeks 1–4	Interview past PM/design clients on willingness to pay; finalise curriculum outline; choose platform; register business structure/ABN; get legal advice on terms of service and insurance/registration questions
1. Build MVP	Weeks 5–12	Write and record Foundations-tier guide and course; build templates and checklists; set up website, checkout, and

Phase	Timing	Key activities
		community shell; publish first 5–10 cornerstone SEO articles; build lead magnet and email funnel
2. Soft launch	Weeks 13–16	Launch to warm network and referral partners at founder pricing; collect testimonials and feedback; iterate on content gaps
3. Public launch	Months 5–6	Full public launch of all three tiers; PR/local media push; open paid add-on booking; ramp content marketing cadence
4. Scale	Months 7–12	Test paid acquisition; formalise referral partnerships with surveyors/planners; add video case studies; begin quarterly content review process
5. Compound & expand	Year 2+	Automate funnel further (evergreen email sequences/webinar); bring on part-time community moderator; evaluate extending the framework to regional Victoria or other states

13. Key Metrics to Track

- **Website/content:** organic traffic, email list growth, lead magnet conversion rate
- **Sales:** visitor-to-customer conversion rate, average order value, tier mix, customer acquisition cost once paid ads begin
- **Retention & community:** optional membership churn, community active-user rate, testimonial/referral rate
- **Consulting:** add-on attach rate, hours booked per week, revenue per consulting hour
- **Overall:** monthly and cumulative revenue by line item against the Section 10 model, updated quarterly

14. Immediate Next Steps

- Confirm business structure (sole trader vs. company) and insurance/registration position with an accountant and Kate's professional body before accepting any paid 1:1 bookings
- Run 5–10 informal conversations with past clients or owner-builder Facebook groups to pressure-test the tier structure and price points in Section 5–6
- Choose a platform (Section 7) and block out the Months 1–4 content production schedule
- Draft the Foundations-tier curriculum outline as the first concrete deliverable

Appendix A: Working Brand Name Options

- The Owner-Builder Pathway
- BuildWise Melbourne

- Site to Sign-Off
- The DIY Build Co.
- Foundations Melbourne

Recommend checking ASIC business name availability and domain/social handle availability before final selection.